

Musket drill
The British Redcoat was renowned for his steadiness in the face of enemy fire – the product of strict drilling, discipline, and long practice of battlefield manoeuvres.

despite mostly being Catholics in the service of a Protestant king and coming from a country simmering with revolt against British rule.

CAMPAIGNING ARMY

The army that Wellington led on campaign in the Peninsular War was a complex and in some ways unwieldy entity. It was a multinational force, including not only Scots and Irish but also large numbers of troops from outside the United Kingdom, notably the King's German Legion. Infantry regiments fought alongside cavalry and artillery regiments but were not integrated with them. The infantry itself included different kinds of troops – "centre companies" of line infantry, and "flanking companies" of light infantry, riflemen, and grenadiers – each of which had its own uniform and fighting methods. There were surgeons of often dubious qualification, chaplains, vets, bandsmen and drummer boys, pioneers for digging trenches and tunnelling during sieges, and commissary's men arranging supplies. A great train of transport, animals, and hangers-on moved with the army on the march. The men were accompanied, for example, by large herds of cattle, with some 300 of the beasts being slaughtered every day to feed the troops in the campaigns of 1813. The hangers-on included prostitutes, but also army wives and, indeed, whole families – one regiment is recorded as taking 48 wives and 20 children along with troops when embarked for Spain.

Marching and counter-marching across Portugal and Spain in the complex campaigns that swayed back and forth year after year was a trial of endurance, especially in the heat of summer. An ordinary soldier carried a load of around 25kg (60lb) and was expected to march around 25km (15 miles) a day. On some occasions men marched for 30 consecutive days from sunrise until dark. Rifleman Harris' account of the British retreat to Corunna and Vigo in 1809 provides a vivid impression of the hardships this occasioned: "Our knapsacks too were a bitter enemy on this prolonged march. Many a man died, I am convinced, who would have borne up well to the end of the retreat but for the infernal load we carried on our backs." Until 1813 tents were not issued and soldiers either built rough-and-ready huts out of any materials they could find or slept in the open. Throughout the Peninsular War, British soldiers suffered a terrible death rate from fevers and exhaustion.

INTO THE BREACH

The spirit of the Redcoat – and his defects – were shown at their starkest in the siege warfare that formed an important part of the Peninsular campaigns. The fortresses of Ciudad Rodrigo, Badajoz, and San Sebastian were all taken by storm after lengthy preparations. A lieutenant observed that none of the soldier's other duties was "so galling or so disagreeable as a siege". For weeks the men would be forced to occupy trenches under the enemy walls, a constant prey to sniping and mortar fire, while gunners and engineers contrived to make a breach in the fortifications. Once a breach was made, they

The storming of Badajoz
An assault party prepares to storm the garrison at Badajoz in April 1812. Around 3,000 English and Portuguese troops were killed in the final successful assault.

